

Guide 35 — Production Planning and Expediting Clerk

Controlled English working master — version 2.0

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What this job is

Production planning and expediting clerks help keep work, materials, parts, and information moving through a production process. Depending on the employer, the same family of work may appear under titles such as production clerk, production scheduler, production assistant, materials coordinator, materials planner, inventory control specialist, production controller, expeditor, or material requirements planning (MRP) coordinator.

The work sits between production, inventory, purchasing, logistics, supervisors, vendors, and customers. A clerk or coordinator may distribute schedules or work orders, check material availability, update records, track delays, communicate changes, and help departments resolve shortages or bottlenecks. More advanced production planner or scheduler roles can involve deeper ERP/MRP use, forecasting, capacity planning, analytics, and responsibility for larger production schedules.

This guide is for career exploration and preparation. Job titles, requirements, wages, and training pathways vary by employer and country. Verify current local requirements before paying for training or accepting a job offer.

What you may do

Typical responsibilities can include:

- distribute production schedules, work orders, or priorities;
- revise schedules when materials, staffing, equipment, design changes, backlogs, or other interruptions affect production;
- check inventory, parts, and material availability against production needs;
- coordinate with production, purchasing, warehouse, logistics, vendors, and customers;
- arrange or follow up on the delivery, assembly, or distribution of supplies and parts;
- document delays, shortages, production problems, and schedule changes;
- compile production, inventory, cost, and progress information;
- enter and maintain accurate records in spreadsheets, databases, ERP, MRP, inventory, or scheduling systems; and
- escalate problems that could affect safety, quality, delivery, or customer commitments.

The exact balance of clerical, scheduling, inventory, logistics, and planning work depends on the facility.

Work environment

Many jobs are based in manufacturing plants, warehouses, production offices, construction-related operations, printing/publishing facilities, or other industrial settings. Some work is primarily office-based, while other roles require regular movement onto a production or warehouse floor.

Possible conditions include time pressure, frequent interruptions, production deadlines, noise, standing or walking, and required personal protective equipment in designated areas. Safety rules are employer- and facility-specific. Never bypass machine-safety, hazardous-material, lockout/tagout, access-control, or PPE requirements to speed up production.

Skills that matter

Employers commonly value:

- careful data entry and recordkeeping;
- spreadsheet skills, including basic formulas, filters, sorting, and simple reports;
- production scheduling and priority tracking;
- inventory and materials awareness;
- familiarity with ERP, MRP, inventory, procurement, or supply-chain systems;
- clear written and verbal communication;
- ability to identify missing information and follow up;
- basic arithmetic and comfort with quantities, dates, lead times, and units;
- organization, accuracy, and attention to detail;
- calm problem solving when schedules change; and
- professional communication across departments and with suppliers or customers.

A particular software product is not universally required. Learn the concepts first, then build familiarity with the systems used by the employers you are targeting.

Education and entry pathways

United States

ONET classifies *Production, Planning, and Expediting Clerks (43-5061.00)* in Job Zone 1–2. Current ONET information indicates that a high school diploma or GED is commonly required, although employer requirements vary and some jobs use different educational thresholds. On-the-job training may range from a few days to as long as a year depending on the complexity of the operation.

A practical entry path can be:

1. Build spreadsheet, business communication, inventory, and production-flow basics.
2. Learn introductory ERP/MRP concepts without assuming one vendor platform is mandatory.
3. Apply for production clerk, materials coordinator, inventory, scheduling assistant, or expeditor roles.

4. Use paid onboarding and cross-training to learn the employer's actual systems and procedures.
5. Progress toward scheduler, materials planner, production planner, or supply-chain roles as your experience grows.

Canada

Government of Canada Job Bank places comparable work under Production logistics workers, NOC 14402. Current national requirements indicate that secondary school completion is usually required. Job Bank currently identifies the occupation as not regulated nationally and does not identify a mandatory professional certification. Employers can still set their own hiring, safety, software, language, or experience requirements.

Colombia

SENA currently lists **Planeación de la Producción**, a 48-hour virtual complementary program, covering production planning concepts such as production costs, capacity calculations, and material requirements planning. Availability and enrollment conditions can change, so verify the current Betowa listing before enrolling.

Colombian job seekers can also use the Ministry of Labour's **Sistema Nacional de Cualificaciones** to explore Formación para el Trabajo and recognition of prior learning, and **OCUPACOL** to explore occupational profiles and related titles. Useful search terms may include *planeador de producción*, *programador de producción*, *auxiliar de producción*, *coordinador de materiales*, *inventarios*, *abastecimiento*, and *logística de producción*.

Latin America and the Caribbean

Training and qualification systems vary by country. OIT/Cinterfor can help you locate national vocational-training and competency systems across the region. Examples include SENA in Colombia, SENCE in Chile, INTECAP in Guatemala, INFOTEP in the Dominican Republic, and INEFOP in Uruguay. Always verify the current program, eligibility, cost, and recognition rules in your own country.

Free-first learning strategy

Do not assume you need an expensive private certificate before applying. A safer sequence is:

1. Review real job postings in your target area and note the recurring skills.
2. Use public or employer-provided training first.
3. Build practical spreadsheet, inventory, scheduling, and ERP/MRP literacy.
4. Ask employers about paid onboarding, cross-training, tuition assistance, reimbursement, or advancement training.
5. Consider paid training only after verifying total cost, refund rules, employer recognition, and whether the credential appears in actual job postings.

Free or low-cost resources may be enough for an entry-level role when combined with transferable experience in administration, inventory, customer service, logistics, warehousing, purchasing, or manufacturing.

Apprenticeship and work-based learning

In the United States, O*NET links this occupation to Registered Apprenticeship titles including Material Coordinator and Production, Planning, and Expediting Clerk. Registered Apprenticeship programs are paid, employer-driven pathways that combine on-the-job learning, mentorship, progressive wage increases, related instruction, and a nationally recognized credential.

Use [Apprenticeship.gov](https://www.apprenticeship.gov) to search current openings. Availability varies by employer and location; the existence of an apprenticeship occupation does not mean a current opening exists in your area.

Elsewhere, look for paid internships, trainee roles, dual-training models, work-study programs, employer apprenticeships, and structured cross-training through public vocational systems and employers.

Funding, grants, and employer support

United States

American Job Centers can help eligible job seekers explore Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act (WIOA) training services. CareerOneStop provides a WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder. Eligibility and funding depend on the individual, state, local workforce area, provider, and program. WIOA funding is not guaranteed.

Canada

Eligible post-secondary learners may qualify for Canada Student Grants and Loans through federal, provincial, or territorial systems. Grants generally do not require repayment; loans do. Eligibility depends on factors such as province or territory, income, dependants, disability status, school, program, tuition, and living costs.

Colombia and Latin America

Check public vocational systems before paying private providers. In Colombia, start with SENA and the national qualifications system. Elsewhere in Latin America, use OIT/Cinterfor to identify the appropriate public vocational institution and verify current funding or enrollment rules.

Employer support

Ask about:

- paid onboarding;
- ERP/MRP or scheduling-system training;
- cross-training with production, inventory, purchasing, or logistics;
- tuition assistance;
- certification reimbursement;
- internships, apprenticeships, or trainee programs; and

- internal promotion pathways.

Get reimbursement conditions in writing before spending money. Some programs require continued employment or repayment if you leave within a specified period.

Income and job outlook

United States — official occupational data

O*NET reports Bureau of Labor Statistics 2025 wage data for Production, Planning, and Expediting Clerks:

- **Median hourly wage: \$28.68**
- **Median annual wage: \$59,650**

O*NET also reports about **388,800 jobs in 2024**, projected employment change of **-1% or lower from 2024 to 2034**, and approximately **34,100 annual openings** over the projection period from growth and replacement needs.

These are national occupational statistics. They are not a promised starting wage and can differ significantly by location, industry, shift, experience, and employer.

United States — current non-government estimates

Private salary sites cover adjacent titles that may carry broader responsibilities than an entry-level clerk:

- Indeed reported an average U.S. base salary of about **\$73,541 per year** for *Production Scheduler*, updated July 20, 2026.
- Salary.com reported an average of about **80,766 per year** for *Production Planner* as of July 1, 2026, with a stated 25th–75th percentile range of **\$73,667–\$89,120**.

These are **non-government market estimates for adjacent titles**, not official occupational medians and not guaranteed earnings.

Canada — official national data

Government of Canada Job Bank currently reports a national median wage of approximately **CAD \$30.77 per hour** for Production Clerk / Production logistics worker work. Local wages and prospects vary. Use Job Bank's location filters before making a training or relocation decision.

A practical 10-week starter plan

Weeks 1–2: Read 15–20 local job postings. Record the most common titles, software, education, shifts, and experience requirements.

Weeks 3–4: Strengthen spreadsheet fundamentals: clean data, sorting, filtering, tables, basic formulas, date calculations, and simple production or inventory tracking.

Weeks 5–6: Learn the concepts behind production schedules, lead time, capacity, bill of materials, inventory status, shortages, safety stock, purchase orders, work orders, and MRP. Focus on concepts rather than memorizing one vendor interface.

Weeks 7–8: Build a small practice exercise. For example, create a simple weekly production schedule in a spreadsheet, track required materials, identify a shortage, revise the schedule, and write a short delay update to a supervisor or customer.

Weeks 9–10: Verify funding, public training, employer support, apprenticeship or trainee options, refund rules, and the actual requirements of the jobs you plan to apply for. Update your resume using truthful examples of coordination, scheduling, inventory, logistics, data accuracy, or problem solving from previous work.

Building experience without already having the title

Transferable experience can come from:

- warehouse or inventory work;
- purchasing or procurement support;
- logistics or shipping/receiving;
- administrative coordination;
- scheduling;
- customer service involving order status or delivery problems;
- manufacturing or production support;
- maintenance planning; or
- retail inventory operations.

When describing experience, show what you actually did. Useful evidence includes reducing errors, keeping records current, coordinating deadlines, resolving shortages, tracking orders, improving handoffs, or maintaining accurate inventory. Do not claim ERP/MRP expertise if you have only studied the concepts.

Advancement

Possible next steps include senior production clerk, production scheduler, materials coordinator, inventory control specialist, materials planner, production planner, supply-chain coordinator, purchasing coordinator, or operations coordinator. Advanced roles may require stronger ERP/MRP knowledge, analytics, manufacturing experience, supply-chain knowledge, supervisory experience, or post-secondary education.

Before paying for a degree or certificate, compare several current job postings for the exact role you want and determine whether the credential is actually requested.

Using AI responsibly in this work

AI tools may help you draft a neutral status update, summarize non-sensitive training notes, create practice interview questions, or explain general planning concepts. They should not

replace the employer's production system, approved calculations, safety procedures, quality controls, or human judgment.

Do not paste confidential production schedules, customer data, supplier pricing, proprietary bills of materials, internal forecasts, employee information, credentials, security details, or other protected business information into a public AI service unless your employer has explicitly approved that use and the data handling is authorized.

Verify AI-generated numbers, dates, quantities, lead times, recommendations, formulas, and citations before using them. A plausible-looking fabrication can cause production delays, inventory errors, financial loss, or safety problems.

Cybersecurity and privacy basics

Production and supply-chain systems can contain commercially sensitive information. Follow your employer's rules for:

- account access and multifactor authentication;
- passwords and credential sharing;
- phishing and suspicious attachments;
- approved file-sharing locations;
- removable media;
- supplier and customer information;
- production schedules and operational data;
- incident reporting; and
- use of personal devices or external AI tools.

If you receive a request to change a supplier bank account, delivery address, purchasing instruction, or production priority through an unusual channel, verify it through the employer's approved process before acting.

Avoid scams and weak training offers

Be cautious when a school, recruiter, or training seller:

- guarantees a job or a specific salary;
- pressures you to pay immediately;
- claims one private certificate is legally required when official sources do not support that claim;
- will not disclose total cost, refund rules, or financing terms;
- cannot explain which employers recognize the credential;
- asks you to pay for a job offer, equipment shipment, or background check through gift cards, cryptocurrency, or an unusual payment method; or
- asks for sensitive identity or banking information before you have verified the organization.

Verify the employer or training provider independently and use official websites whenever possible.

When to pause before spending money

Pause or delay enrollment when:

- local job postings do not require the credential you are considering;
- the provider will not give total costs and refund terms in writing;
- public or employer-paid training may cover the same skill;
- you have not confirmed whether the program is recognized by employers in your area;
- the schedule or physical demands do not fit your circumstances; or
- the financing terms create debt you cannot comfortably repay.

Current sources

Official/public sources:

- U.S. Department of Labor O*NET OnLine — Production, Planning, and Expediting Clerks: <https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/43-5061.00>
- Apprenticeship.gov — Career Seekers: <https://www.apprenticeship.gov/career-seekers>
- CareerOneStop — WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder: <https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/EmploymentAndTraining/find-WIOA-training-programs.aspx>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Production logistics workers: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/occupation/2460/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — requirements: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/requirements/2477/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — wages/summary: <https://on.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/summary-occupation/2474/ca>
- Canada Student Grants and Loans: <https://www.canada.ca/en/services/benefits/education/student-aid/grants-loans.html>
- SENA Betowa — Planeación de la Producción: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/planeacion-de-la-produccion?modality=V&offertype=open&programId=175616>
- Colombia Ministerio del Trabajo — Sistema Nacional de Cualificaciones: <https://cualificaciones.mintrabajo.gov.co/>
- Colombia Ministerio del Trabajo — OCUPACOL: <https://ocupacol.mintrabajo.gov.co/>
- OIT/Cinterfor: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/>

Supplementary non-government salary sources:

- Indeed — Production Scheduler salaries: <https://www.indeed.com/career/production-scheduler/salaries>
- Salary.com — Production Planner salary: <https://www.salary.com/research/salary/position/production-planner-salary>

Source and review note

This guide uses current-source research recorded on August 12, 2026. Wages, training availability, program rules, software expectations, and local hiring conditions can change. Recheck official sources and current job postings before acting.

This controlled revision was produced with AI assistance and auditable source review. It does **not** claim independent human certification, professional accreditation, certified translation, legal review, financial advice, or guaranteed employment outcomes.